

A BOOK OF TASTE / II

The Patisserie of the Unconscious

Cannoli

PLEASURE



Even restraint can invent sweetness.

The Arab Gift

9th — 11th century · Sicily



Under Arab rule, Sicily received sugarcane, citrus, almonds and the art of working them — the foundation of everything sweet the island would later invent.

Ricotta, sugar and spice met on the same table for the first time. The cannolo did not yet exist, but its ingredients had already arrived.

HISTORY / 02

Behind the Convent Grille

Medieval — Baroque · Palermo — Caltanissetta



For centuries the island's finest confectioners were nuns. Behind grilles and vows, convents perfected cannoli, cassata and marzipan fruit.

The sweets were sold through a turnstile window — the ruota — to fund the houses. Pleasure was produced by enclosure, and passed to the world without a face.

HISTORY / 04

The Taste of the Island

19th century — today · Sicily — the world



As convent kitchens faded, the recipe passed to town pastry shops and family trade, and the cannolo left the calendar of feast days to belong to any ordinary afternoon.

Today it travels the world as shorthand for Sicilian pleasure — dolce far niente, the sweetness of doing nothing, folded into one crisp shell.

AFTERTASTE

A carnival treat had become the taste of Sicily itself.

A SMALL PRACTICE

Make something beautiful without waiting for a special occasion. Let pleasure exist without turning it into a reward.

What small pleasure have you postponed until life becomes less busy?

RECIPE / INGREDIENTS

Simple Ricotta Cannoli

A simplified home version using ready-made shells.

- 8 ready-made cannoli shells
- 300 g ricotta
- 80 g powdered sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- zest of 1 orange or lemon
- 40 g chopped pistachios or dark chocolate
- extra powdered sugar



RECIPE / METHOD

- 01 Drain the ricotta if necessary.
 - 02 Mix ricotta, sugar, vanilla, and citrus zest.
 - 03 Fold in pistachios or chocolate.
 - 04 Chill for 20–30 minutes.
 - 05 Fill the shells shortly before serving.
 - 06 Dust lightly with powdered sugar.
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A cannolo takes minutes to fill, but the sweetness inside it was assembled over a thousand years.